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FUNDRAISING



How to actually raise a seed round: Actionable advice from top investors at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025



[TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) returns to Moscone West in San Francisco from October 27-29, bringing together more than 10,000 startup and VC leaders for an inside look at where innovation is headed. Among the must-attend sessions is a candid panel on the Builders Stage about one of the most high-stakes moments in any founder's journey: raising your first round.

[Register now to save up to \\$675 on your ticket](#) and join this conversation — plus 200+ more sessions across five industry stages, roundtables, and breakouts. Prices go up tonight at 11:59 p.m. PT.

IMAGE CREDITS:



From pitch to partnership: The real roadmap to seed funding

This dynamic panel brings together three seasoned investors — Maria Palma (Freestyle Capital), Gabby Cazeau (Harlem Capital), and Marlon Nichols (MaC Venture Capital) — to unpack the realities of early-

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October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

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stage fundraising. From shaping a compelling pitch to choosing the right capital partners, they'll share honest, actionable insights to help founders translate interest into investment.

[Maria Palma](#), general partner at [Freestyle Capital](#), brings deep operating and investing experience, with past roles at Kindred Capital, RRE Ventures, and leadership positions at high-growth startups like Eyeview. She's backed companies such as Fung Money, Lightning Labs, and Payman, and holds an MBA from Harvard.

[Gabby Cazeau](#) is a partner at [Harlem Capital](#), investing in pre-seed and seed startups across enterprise software and applied AI. She holds an MBA from Yale and a BS in chemical engineering. Gabby has been featured in Business Insider, CNBC, and Crain's 40 Under 40, and serves on the VC Council of Startup:NYC.

[Marlon Nichols](#), co-founder and managing general partner of [MaC Venture Capital](#), leads one of North America's top seed-stage firms with over \$600 million AUM (assets under management). A multiple-time honoree on Business Insider's Seed 100 and PitchBook's list of top Black VCs, Marlon has helped scale industry-shaping companies like Blavity, Thrive Market, and MongoDB.

What to expect on the Builders Stage

This isn't your typical venture panel. Expect sharp insights on how to cut through the noise, structure your raise, and build relationships that last beyond a term sheet. Whether you're gearing up for your first round or advising a founder who is, this is the session you don't want to miss.

- Lina Khan points to Figma IPO as vindication of M&A scrutiny
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Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

Catch Palma, Cazeau, Nichols, and [250+ tech heavyweights](#) across the six industry-specific stages, as well as in breakouts and roundtables, live at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025, at Moscone West in San Francisco. [Register now](#) and lock in up to \$675 in ticket savings before today ends!

Topics: [Disrupt 2025](#) [Fundraising](#) [Startups](#) [TC](#)

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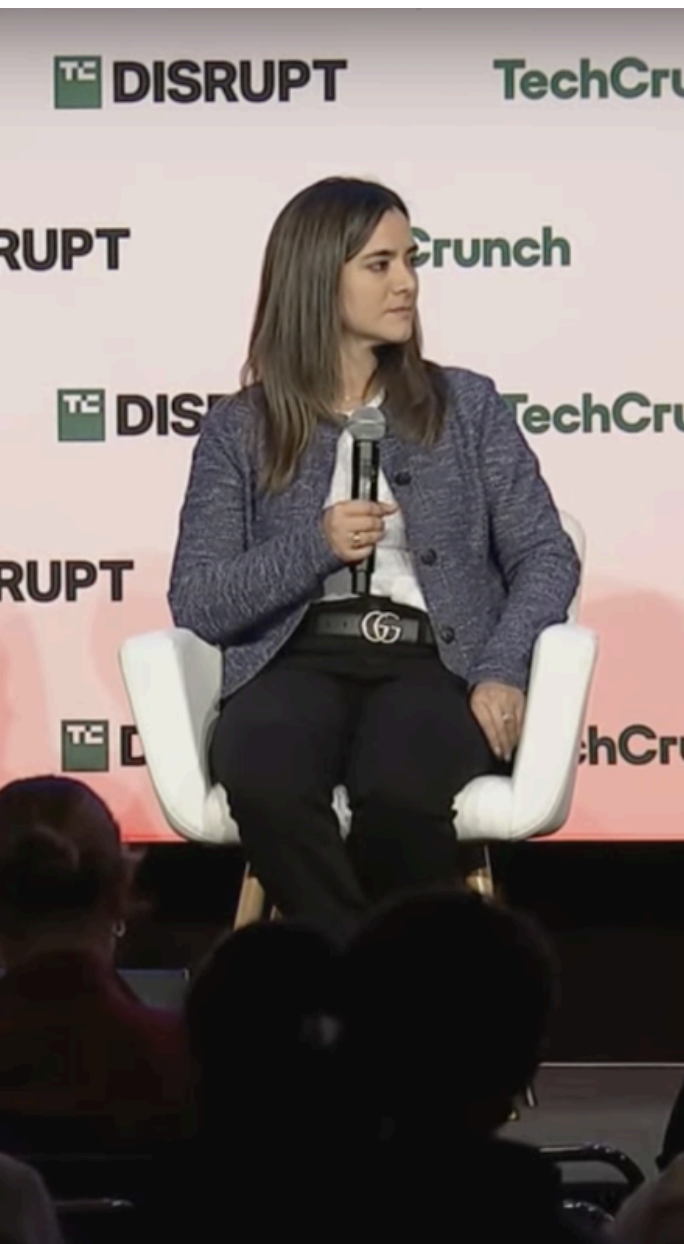


IMAGE CREDITS:

SLAVA BLAZER PHOTOGRAPHY / GETTY IMAGES

VENTURE



Introducing the Going Public Stage at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events — 9:01 AM PDT · June 25, 2025

For the first time ever, [TechCrunch Disrupt](#) is launching the Going Public Stage — a brand-new destination for founders navigating the mid and late stages of company building.

This content is essential for any founder, but especially those scaling fast, preparing for exit, or reimagining what comes next. Because whether you're at the seed stage or Series E, the most successful founders are always thinking 10 steps ahead.

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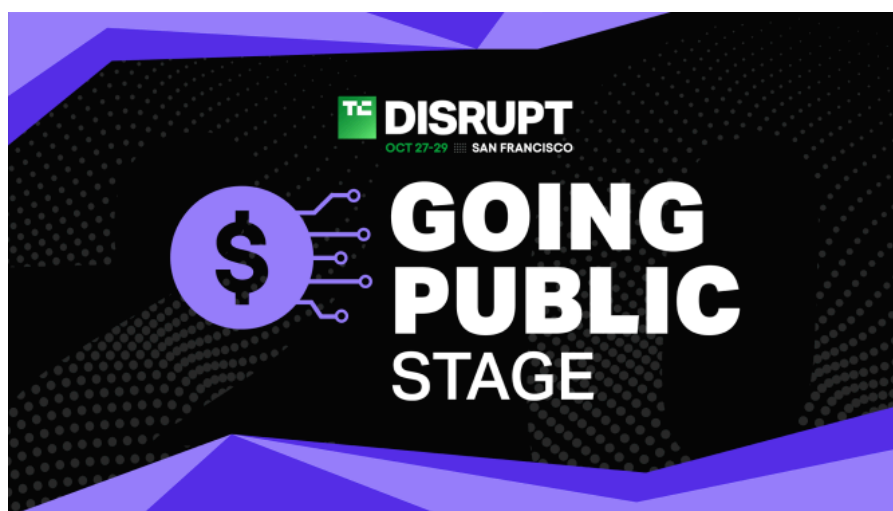


Every weekday and Sunday, you can get the best of TechCrunch's coverage.

You'll hear from some of the biggest names in tech and venture — including Julie Wainwright ([The RealReal](#)), David George ([Andreessen Horowitz](#)), and Nirav Tolia ([Nextdoor](#)) — as they share hard-won lessons on building resilient companies, navigating shifting markets, and staying ahead of the curve.

From IPO prep to AI-powered GTM strategy, this stage is your roadmap for building what's next.

Stay tuned — more [sessions](#) and [speakers](#) are coming soon. In the meantime, mark the Going Public Stage as a can't-miss at Disrupt, and [grab your ticket now to save up to \\$675](#).



How Long Should a Startup Stay Private?

[David George](#), general partner, Andreessen Horowitz

Startups today can grow to huge valuations, cash out their employees, and stay private longer than those of previous eras. But that also means that late-stage startups are facing a whole new set of rules. George unpacks the shifting VC landscape, what the next generation of scaled startups needs to know, and how capital is being deployed in an era of tighter money and higher expectations. From IPO windows to secondary markets to the evolving role of growth investors, this fireside chat goes deep on

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what it really takes to build enduring companies in today's market — and what's coming next.



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Go public, get acquired, or double down and stay private? In today's unpredictable market, founders need to think about exit strategy earlier — and more strategically — than ever. This panel brings together two top VCs and a seasoned CFO to unpack how to set your company up for every option. We'll talk timing, metrics that matter, investor expectations, and what it really takes to navigate M&A, IPO prep, or just keep building through the storm. Whether you're 12 months out or just starting to scale, this conversation is all about making smart moves now for whatever comes next.



Building What Comes Next

Julie Wainwright, CEO, [Ahara](#); founder and former CEO, TheRealReal

Wainwright knows how to spot a wave — and ride it. From pioneering luxury resale at The RealReal to jumping into personalized nutrition with Ahara, she's made a career out of building ahead of the curve. In this fireside chat, Wainwright opens up about what it takes to start over, scale fast, and stay resilient through market shifts and personal pivots. We'll dig into the lessons learned from category creation, the risks of reinvention, and why experience might just be the ultimate startup edge.

How AI Is Forcing Late-stage Startups to Rewire GTM — or Be Left Behind

[Jane Alexander](#), partner, CapitalG; [Vanessa Larco](#), co-founder, Premise; and [Nirav Tolia](#), CEO, Nextdoor

AI is rewriting the playbook for how startups reach and win customers, and late-stage companies are feeling the pressure to adapt fast. In this panel, two top VCs and a seasoned founder break down how AI is transforming go-to-market strategies, from sales and marketing to customer success. We'll get into what's working, what's hype, and how to build AI

into your GTM engine without losing focus. If you're scaling and wondering how AI fits into your next phase of growth, this is the conversation you don't want to miss.

Ready to exit? Start at Disrupt 2025

Whether you're weighing an acquisition, eyeing the IPO window, or mapping out your ideal exit, the [Going Public Stage at Disrupt 2025](#) is built for founders ready to make their next big move. Hear from leaders who've navigated the highs, the risks, and the reinventions — and walk away with insights you can act on now.

Don't wait to sharpen your exit strategy. [Secure your pass to Disrupt 2025 and save up to \\$675](#) before prices rise. More sessions and speakers are coming soon, but this stage alone is worth the ticket.

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STARTUPS



Do startups still need Silicon Valley? Hear from the founders and funders challenging old assumptions at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events — 7:30 AM PDT · July 28, 2025

As the startup world descends on San Francisco for [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) — happening October 27-29 at Moscone West — one question looms large: Does building in Silicon Valley still give founders an edge? With 10,000+ startup and VC leaders gathering for this milestone Disrupt, the conversation around access, geography, and opportunity has never been more timely.

On the [Builders Stage](#), Anh-Tho Chuong (Lago), David Hall (Revolution), and Heather Doshay (SignalFire) lead a must-attend session for anyone looking to scale smart in today's startup landscape.

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- 17 hours ago

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Why this conversation matters now

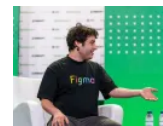
As distributed teams, regional hubs, and global fundraising become more normalized, founders are increasingly asking if their ZIP code actually gives them an edge. Does being in the Bay Area still open the right doors? Or has the playing field finally leveled?

This [session](#) brings together startup veterans and seasoned investors who've built and backed companies across the country — and well beyond it. They'll dig into what access looks like in 2025, how remote collaboration has evolved post-pandemic, and where true opportunity lies for emerging founders.

Who's taking the Builders Stage for this session

[Anh-Tho Chuong](#) is rethinking open source billing with [Lago](#), a YC-backed platform trusted by AI leaders like Mistral and Together. From her time scaling Qonto to her early roles at Weebly and

STARTUPS



Figma's IPO success is 'a little bit of a meme stock,' says Sapphire Ventures' Jai Das

Rebecca Bellan,
Theresa Loconsolo
- 19 hours ago

STARTUPS



Payment platform Lava raises \$5.8M to build digital wallets for the 'agent-native economy'

Dominic-Madori Davis
- 20 hours ago

McKinsey, she's no stranger to navigating growth across continents.

[David Hall](#) has spent the last decade proving that game-changing companies don't have to come out of Silicon Valley. As managing partner at [Revolution](#)'s Rise of the Rest Seed Fund, he's helped build a portfolio that spans the country — backing bold founders in places often overlooked by coastal VCs.

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[Heather Doshay](#) knows how to scale people-first organizations from the inside. As a partner at [SignalFire](#) and former VP of People at Webflow, she's seen how the hiring landscape has shifted for startups outside the Valley — and what it takes to build standout teams in a distributed world.

Join the debate at Disrupt

Whether you're building from a big city, a small town, or somewhere in between, this session will

offer a fresh perspective on where startup success really comes from. Find out what still matters, what doesn't, and how to build your network — no matter your location.

Catch this panel live on the [Builders Stage](#) at Disrupt 2025, happening October 27-29 at Moscone West in San Francisco. Tickets are moving fast, and prices increase after July — [register now to save up to \\$675](#) and lock in your spot.



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